

E.U. LOAN TO KYIV
PROVIDES LIFELINE
FOR WAR EFFORT

FILLING GAP LEFT BY U.S.

Billions in Aid to Ukraine
Reflect a Belief That
Peace Is Far Off

By CONSTANT MÉHEUT

KYIV, Ukraine — For weeks, Ukraine had been caught in a bind. A path to ending the war seemed increasingly illusory, as peace talks with Russia went from yielding no results to being put on hold. That meant Kyiv needed to prepare to fight indefinitely, even as vital financial support from the European Union remained frozen.

On Thursday, a breakthrough finally arrived.

After Hungary dropped its opposition to a \$106 billion E.U. loan to Ukraine the day before, European leaders unblocked the funds. The money, which had been held up since December, will cover a large share of Ukraine's financial needs over the next two years. Once those funds are exhausted, an additional \$117 billion from the bloc's long-term budget is expected to be allocated to Ukraine.

Taken together, the pledges appear to put Ukraine on firmer financial footing at least through 2029, said Hlib Vyshlinsky, head of the Kyiv-based Center for Economic Strategy. The pressure, he added, now shifts to Moscow, which is facing growing economic challenges in sustaining its own war effort.

In addition to the loan, the European Union adopted its 20th package of economic sanctions against Russia on Thursday.

"Deadlock over," Kaja Kallas, the E.U. foreign policy chief, wrote on social media. "Russia's war economy is under growing strain, while Ukraine is getting a major boost."

The European Union's extended commitment to Ukraine has largely filled a void left by the Trump administration. Last year,

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At a pro-government rally in Iran this month, people held posters of the father and son ayatollahs. But an outside expert said, "Mojtaba is not yet in full command."

In Iran's New Leadership Structure, the Generals Hold the Power

By FARNAZ FASSIHI

When Ayatollah Ali Khamenei ruled Iran as the supreme leader, he exerted absolute power over all decisions about war, peace and negotiations with the United States. His son and successor does not play the same role.

Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, the son, is an elusive figure who has not been seen and whose voice has not been heard since he was appointed in March. Instead, a battle-hardened collective of commanders in the Islamic Revolutionary

Guards Corps and those aligned with them are the key decision makers on matters of security, war and diplomacy.

"Mojtaba is managing the country as though he is the director of the board," said Abdolreza Davari, a politician who served as senior adviser to Mahmoud Ahmadinejad when he was president and knows Mr. Khamenei.

"He relies heavily on the advice and guidance of the board members, and they collectively make all the decisions," Mr. Davari said by phone from Tehran. "The generals are the board members."

Hardened Circle Rules
for Injured Ayatollah

This account of Iran's new power structure is based on interviews with six senior Iranian officials, two former officials, two members of the Revolutionary Guards, a senior cleric familiar with the inner workings of the system and three individuals who know Mr. Khamenei well. Nine other individuals with ties to the

Guards and the government also described the command structure. They all spoke on the condition they not be identified because they were discussing sensitive matters of state.

Mr. Khamenei, who was selected by a council of senior clerics as the new supreme leader, has been in hiding since American and Israeli forces bombed his father's compound on Feb. 28, where he also lived with his family. His father, wife and son were all killed. Access to him is extremely difficult and limited now. He is surrounded mostly by a team of doc-

tors and medical staff who are treating the injuries he sustained in the airstrikes.

Senior commanders of the Guards and senior government officials do not visit him, fearing that Israel may trace them to him and kill him. President Masoud Pezeshkian, who is also a heart surgeon, and the minister of

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ISRAEL-LEBANON President Trump announced a three-week extension of a cease-fire. PAGE A5

Capitol Officer Enmeshed in Jan. 6 Conspiracy

By CORINA KNOLL

The phone call on that Thursday afternoon brought an emphatic demand: Report to the C.I.A. office immediately.

Shauni Kerkhoff had been with the agency for four years and would have normally been at work then. But her schedule had been altered during a government shutdown, so she was enjoying a day off, curled up in her living room, the dogs nearby.

It did not cross Ms. Kerkhoff's mind to decline, or demand more information from her supervisor. She had made it a habit to be professional and upbeat, having chosen law enforcement because she believed she could be helpful to the community.

At 31 years old, her enthusiasm



Shauni Kerkhoff was falsely tied to planted pipe bombs.

for her career had already been tested, and in an unimaginable way. Her first job in the Washington area was as a Capitol Police officer, and she had faced off against

the mob of rioters on Jan. 6, 2021. She relived the insurrection while working with federal prosecutors and testifying in two criminal trials — and then watched those convictions unravel when President Trump pardoned hundreds of the day's participants.

She had gone on to join the C.I.A., where she received multiple promotions and performance awards. But when she arrived at a federal building in Virginia on Nov. 6 last year, she was told to join two F.B.I. agents in a windowless conference room.

The agents had come, they said, because of what had taken place the night before the storming of the Capitol. On Jan. 5, 2021, surveillance cameras captured someone placing pipe bombs near the headquarters of the Democratic

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He was the director of the San Francisco Symphony for 25 years.

MICHAEL TILSON THOMAS, 1944-2026

Revered American Conductor
And Classical Music Evangelist

By ANTHONY TOMMASINI

Michael Tilson Thomas, the American conductor, composer and pianist whose 25-year tenure as music director of the San Francisco Symphony became a model of collegial music-making, artistic adventurousness and community engagement, died on Wednesday at his home in San Francisco. He was 81.

The cause was glioblastoma, an aggressive form of brain cancer, Constance Shuman, his publicist, said in a statement.

Mr. Thomas announced in the summer of 2021 that he had had surgery for a brain tumor. In March 2022, he specified that he had been diagnosed with glioblastoma.

Although Mr. Thomas's prognosis seemed ominous and he was forced to cancel some scheduled performances, for more than three years he rallied and led a number of inspiring concerts in San Francisco, Los Angeles, London and elsewhere. In September 2024, he opened the New York Philharmonic's season with an account of Mahler's mighty Fifth

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A Must-Have Doll May Contain Banned Cotton

This article is by Ana Swanson, Sapna Maheshwari and Meaghan Tobin.

Over the past two years, a furry monster with bunny ears and a vicious line of serrated teeth became the subject of a global craze, as shoppers waited hours in line or paid hundreds or thousands of dollars for the most coveted Labubus.

The boom turned Pop Mart, the Chinese company that sells Labubus, into a global brand. But



Some Labubus have cotton banned by a forced labor law.

a test of the doll — the results of which The New York Times has independently confirmed — showed that clothing on certain Labubu dolls contains cotton from the Xinjiang region of western China, which the U.S. government has banned because of its association with forced labor.

For businesses like Pop Mart, selling products that contain cotton banned in the United States could have severe consequences. Companies found in violation of a

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Enshrining an Ex-President

Interior Secretary Doug Burgum says Theodore Roosevelt belongs in the Pro Football Hall of Fame. PAGE B9

Warriors? Cavs? Retire?

A recent resurgence by LeBron James and the Lakers might persuade him to re-up this summer. PAGE B6

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G.O.P. Licks Its Wounds

A voter map victory for Democrats in Virginia has left Republicans grumbling and looking to the next phase of a coast-to-coast battle, possibly Florida. PAGE A11

New Push for Denaturalization

The Trump administration is assigning cases to federal prosecutors, which could lead to a surge of people stripped of their U.S. citizenship. PAGE A15

Hudson Yards Plan in Question

Eric Adams agreed with Related Companies to finance a costly platform, but Mayor Zohran Mamdani said advancing the deal was not a priority. PAGE A16

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A.I. Model Sets Off Alarms

Anthropic's Mythos has brought crisis responses from central banks and intelligence agencies globally. PAGE B1

Onion Has New Infowars Plan

A new deal, which would let the satirical news outlet use the Infowars name and site, needs approval. PAGE B1

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Grim Choice for Afghan Allies

Afghan refugees who helped U.S. forces say they face "bad or worse" options: resettlement in Congo or returning home to live under the Taliban. PAGE A9

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Many Stones Left Unturned

A biopic produced by the estate of Michael Jackson provides a very sanitized version of the star. PAGE C5

'Rocky Horror,' Reborn

The revival, with Stephanie Hsu and Andrew Durand, below, tries to recapture a sense of big gay mayhem. PAGE C1

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Ivory Tower Iconoclast

Andrew Hacker, whose books challenged conventional thinking on issues like race relations, was 96. PAGE A21

A Versatile French Actress

Nathalie Baye, 77, was admired for her naturalness and became a familiar face in cinema over four decades. PAGE A20

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Jessica Grose

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